

2028?

PLAYING SOOTHSAYER is a terrible job, because more often than not, things never go the way they should and technology blindsides us so consistently that we're all just a little terrified to make predictions. Why? Because we know they will come back and bite us in the backside eventually. In fact, the prediction game is such a minefield that most prefer to leap straight into the distant future and dabble more in science fiction than in real predictions that can be proven wrong in just a few years.

What's worse, when you do it for a well regarded publication like Digit, it's something a lot of people read, and then hold you accountable for. It's why every single columnist that follows me is really a brave soul, sticking their neck out for technology and Digit, and that's something I respect deeply. Whether it's members of our inhouse team, or external columnists, or even the feature stories that follow them all, everyone is basing their vision on research, or insider knowledge. And even then we will get it all a little wrong.

Why does that happen? Because the very nature of technology and science makes it so. Tech is invading every aspect of life, and every field of study. Whether it's giving people computational models to test their theories, or finding patterns that humans just cannot do, technology has been enhancing human abilities ever since the first hominid picked up a stick.

At its most basic level, that's all technology really is... an enhancement of human capabilities, which is now being taken to levels far beyond what humans were ever meant to achieve.

I'm writing this column before anyone else has submitted theirs, and since this is the year of AI (as our Jan 2018 issue announced), I'm

betting that at least a few will talk about AI. And all this chatter about AI is not because it's the buzzword of the year... it's the buzzword of the year because of all the work being done on it. It's only now, where computers are powerful number crunchers, but do so at far lower power usage than ever before, storage is cheap but still fast, and networking speeds are through the roof, which allows for proper distributed / grid computing that AI is feasible.

That's not the only reason though, because going hand-in-hand with all of this number crunching capability, is the type of numbers they're crunching. Data was always money for businesses, because large amounts of data on products and consumers is worth its weight in gold. That was when data was hard to come by... now, with all of us literally throwing our data out there, it's just begging to be analysed and acted upon immediately... something machines are just the best at.

In case you've noticed, I haven't made any predictions yet, and no I'm not trying to worm out of doing so, because inside you will find a much longer article by me, which does exactly that. The purpose of this column is to set the stage for all the opinions that follow, and I hope I've done at least that.

If you absolutely insist on a prediction... everything major that happens over the next decade, good or bad, will undoubtedly have technology and science involved in a big way.

Now is the part where you will probably say "Thanks Captain Obvious!", and flip the page in disgust!

Before you do though, don't you think it's pretty magnificent to be a geek living in a world that's will forever more be ruled by technology? 



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